separate plebiscites in the various regions that had been combined by Gulab Singh and his successors into a single polity under Dogra rule.

Sheikh Abdullah's emergency government was announced by the Maharaja at the end of October 1947; it was a 'peculiar diarchy'. Mahajan was still the Prime Minister but effective political power lay in the hands of a cabinet presided over by Abdullah and his National Conference associates—Bakshi Ghulam Mohammed, Mirza Afzal Beg and G. M. Sadiq. These men were answerable to no elected assembly and their relationships with Mahajan and the Maharaja, who represented a dying regime, were far from cordial. India, by virtue of Nehru's repeated declarations that Abdullah represented the true voice of the Kashmiri people, could do little at this stage to control the actions of its own nominee.

Concurrent events soon demonstrated that Sheikh Abdullah, for all his opposition to the Maharaja and to Jinnah, was no subservient follower of India. His regime had, from the outset, showed signs of being a potential dictatorship and was soon seen to be exhibiting a form of arbitrary and extreme government, so much so, that it would be difficult for even Nehru to defend. Fortunately for Nehru's reputation, the military situation in the state and the rhetoric of Indo-Pakistan arguments distracted attention from what Abdullah was really up to. But, his actions were all too apparent to those directly involved in Kashmiri affairs. Within six weeks of having been entrusted with the state's administration, Mahajan began complaining to Sardar Patel that the state government reminded him of Nazi Germany, run by gangsters and he added that he wished to be, in no way, associated with it. The sooner he was out, the better.[1]

The state high court had been prevented from functioning effectively. Large numbers of officials in the Maharaja's old administration, including the governor of Jammu, had been detained. Abdullah had appointed several of his friends as senior officials without consulting Mahajan. National Conference workers were selling trade concessions and renting out state transport vehicles without any interference from the government. Members of the Muslim Conference, whom the Maharaja had arrested, were left languishing in captivity.